this kind was hearing from a lady whose prize show horse had received such a letter.”

When the weather allowed it, we went for a ride at Camp David, and on some weekends we opened the back gate and rode through the lush green national forest surrounding it, following an old road that passed the tumbledown stone ruins of a onetime summer hotel. During the early 1930s, the hotel had been owned by a young woman named Bessie Darling whose boyfriend was a local doctor. One night, according to her maid, who still lived nearby, the doctor, who had been told Bessie was dating someone else, arrived at the hotel and demanded to see the mistress. The maid went upstairs to tell Bessie, who was asleep alone in bed. But the doctor, apparently in a fit of jealousy and expecting to find another man, followed her up the stairs, holding a gun. Bessie got out of bed and reached for a gun she had tucked under her pillow for protection; she had the gun in her hand when her doctor-lover shot her dead in front of the maid. The doctor was arrested and claimed self-defense, but because the gun in Bessie’s hand hadn’t been cocked and the safety was still on, he was convicted and sent to prison.

During World War II, the old lodge was used as a safe house where President Roosevelt sometimes met secretly with foreign intelligence officers. Later, a fire all but destroyed the lodge and left only a pile of ruins. Everyone joked that the ruins were haunted by the young woman who died there, and every time I passed on a horse, I’d say, “Hi, Bessie.”

The one thing I always missed during our weekends at Camp David was a chance to go to church. But I prayed that God would realize that when I was out in the beautiful forest I felt as if I was in His temple.

The ghost of Bessie Darling, incidentally, wasn’t the only one we heard about while we were in Washington.